quality and speed of decision-making; it does not replace the judgement, accountability, and contextual wisdom that effective governance demands. The organisations that will lead are those that deploy AI to sharpen human insight and not as a substitute for it. Strategic direction must remain firmly grounded in human experience and responsibility. That boundary is not a limitation; it is the foundation of sound governance.

What are the most underestimated legal risks when businesses integrate AI into core operations?

There are three I would highlight. First, regulatory and compliance uncertainty, businesses are deploying AI without fully mapping evolving governance frameworks, sectoral obligations, and cross-border legal exposure, which creates material liability risk that many have not yet priced in. Second, the reliability of AI outputs: when results are inconsistent or difficult to explain, the legal and operational consequences can be significant. Third, and perhaps most underestimated, are the ethical and reputational risks. Bias, opacity, and unfair outcomes translate quickly into legal challenges and the erosion of stakeholder trust. These are not theoretical future risks. They are present, operational realities that demand immediate boardroom attention.

As AI adoption scales, how should liability be allocated between developers, deployers, and users?

Liability must be approached as a shared and carefully structured responsibility and not assigned to a single actor. Developers, deployers, and users each occupy distinct roles, and liability should broadly track control and knowledge at each stage. In practice, this will largely be shaped through contractual architecture: warranties, indemnities, and limitations on liability carefully calibrated to reflect each party's actual exposure and accountability. Alongside this, intellectual property questions are becoming increasingly material such as ownership of AI-generated outputs, use of third-party training data, and related IP risks must be addressed explicitly.

Businesses need a combination of clear contracts, strong internal governance, and ongoing oversight to manage these risks effectively. Leaving them to assumption is no longer defensible.

Your firm has embedded AI into its own workflows. What does genuine integration look like and what does it demand of a law firm?

We have moved decisively from cautious experimentation to embedding AI within our core legal workflows. We deploy tools including Harvey AI, Microsoft Copilot, and Litera for secure content search, drafting, summarisation, document review, and due diligence. The efficiency gains are real and measurable. For e.g., research and documentation cycles have shortened considerably. But this has also resharpened our talent paradigm: the combination of deep legal knowledge and genuine technical literacy is now a valued and necessary professional skill set. Critically, every deployment operates within strict governance protocols to ensure client confidentiality is protected without exception. True integration is not about adopting tools, it is about embedding them responsibly into the professional fabric of the firm.

Are AI-related disputes and regulatory scrutiny rising or is the market still in early-stage legal friction?

Both are clearly rising, though the market is still evolving in its response. Regulators are becoming noticeably more proactive, particularly around data protection, algorithmic accountability, and sector-specific compliance and that is prompting businesses to exercise greater caution in their AI deployments. On the disputes side, we are beginning to see issues surface around liability, misuse of data, and contractual breaches. Many of these remain at a relatively early stage, but the trajectory is clear. As AI adoption deepens and its outputs become more consequential, both regulatory intervention and high-stakes disputes will grow in frequency and complexity. Businesses that wait for that moment to build their legal frameworks will find themselves significantly behind.

Turning to ESG, are we approaching a point where sustainability becomes a test of corporate survival, not just reputation?

Absolutely. We are witnessing a structural redefinition of corporate viability itself. Financial resilience in isolation is no longer a sufficient indicator of long-term survival. Businesses that are misaligned with transition pathways will face capital constraints, regulatory friction, and eventual market exclusion. Sustainability is not an adjunct to going concern, it is fast becoming its precondition.

Your firm has built a dedicated ESG, carbon, and climate practice. What is the larger ambition?

Our role has always extended beyond client advisory into ecosystem building. As early movers, we bridge the gap between policy, capital, and enterprise, guiding clients through an evolving regulatory landscape, contributing to policy dialogue, structuring first-of-their-kind transactions, and setting market benchmarks. ESG advisory is catalysing a shift from reactive lawyering to genuine market-making. Law firms today have both the opportunity and the responsibility to help construct the system and not merely advise within it. The objective is to help institutionalise ESG as a core pillar of India's economic architecture.

What is your message to India Inc. and to the next generation of lawyers entering this space?

To India Inc.: AI and ESG are converging into a single, powerful filter for competitive advantage. Companies that embed both into their strategy will attract capital, command stronger valuations, and build durable resilience. Those that treat them as peripheral will find themselves out of step with regulators, investors, and markets. The gap will close faster than most anticipate. The leadership map of India Inc. is being redrawn. The decisive question is whether you are building the enterprise that address both aspects simultaneously.

To young lawyers: you will be the primary catalysts of this transformation. ESG and AI demand fluency across law, finance, policy, and science, areas where the next generation is uniquely positioned to lead. You will not merely operate within the system. You will redefine its contours.